

Web Space

- Forty four per cent of all urban online Indians use social networking websites, 52 per cent of which belong to the below-25 age group
- The online social networking boom has seen a surge in websites by Indian companies each competing for space along side Orkut and Facebook
- A platform for political and social discourse has been created as young, promising politicians and even some old ones use these site to connect to the people
- Blogging provides an important platform to publish thoughts, opinions and points of view. It has become the common person's open space
- Law enforcement has its work cut out with increased reports of misuse of profiles and photographs

ship of a laptop or computer (75 per cent) and about 31 per cent graduated from professional streams.

Social networking websites are perhaps misty reflections of the IT boom. But that hasn't stopped firms—like Google with Orkut and Reliance Entertainment with BigAdda—from cashing in on their popularity. Entrepreneurs aren't far behind either. Like Minglebox's Kavita Iyer who quit a corporate job to start a college networking website with her friends. Iyer doesn't believe that social networking is a brief fad, a temporary flash in the pan. Instead, she says, there is a need for social networking among Internet users. "Users have moved away from traditional media to the Internet and this is just the beginning of the way social and other interactions will be transformed by the new media," she says.

Perhaps one such form of interaction is blogging, a user's very own publishing platform. There are no censors or editors. Instead, the commentary ranges from the political to the humorous. A free space, blogs reflect the unheard voice of the private citizen. As well as that of the famous. Like actor Aamir Khan who used his blog to promote his new film.

The social networking success story most-quoted is of Facebook founded in 2004 by Mark Zuckerberg, an undergraduate at Harvard, US. Over three years later, the site has

nearly 50 million users with a repeated daily usage of 70 per cent. Wired.com in October reported the website's value was around \$15 billion. Microsoft was ready to shell out \$240 billion for a 1.6 per cent share of the Facebook pie.

India's preferred choice is Orkut with two in three social networkers (64 per cent) preferring the website. In fact, India is the third largest user of Orkut after Brazil and the US. No wonder then that young, tech-savvy netas use it as an effective tool to connect with the rest of the country, a necessary platform for their propaganda. Like Lok Sabha member Deepender Hooda, son of Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda and Akhilesh Yadav, son of Samajwadi Party president Mulayam Singh Yadav. And then there was a rally held in support of Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi. This one was made up of supporters who met at Namo, an Orkut community dedicated to the politician. While fan clubs and hate groups are common on social networking sites, this is perhaps the first time that one such community organised a political rally.

Communities set up on these networking websites are fast becoming a successful tool for social and political discussions. Some flip-pant, no doubt, but many that have even made their way into India's courts and also aided enforcement agencies. Like an anti-India group hosted on Orkut that saw the Maharashtra Government giving Google a notice in 2006.

But behind this rosy picture is a dark underbelly. In August this year, Mumbai teenager Adnan Patrawala was kidnapped and murdered, allegedly by friends he made on Orkut. Enforcement agencies in Delhi and Mumbai report an increase in complaints from users on misuse of profiles. Like the Delhi schoolgirl who in February this year found her pictures and a fake profile on a site.

Despite doomsday stories of things gone wrong, social networking is the new revolution within the IT revolution. Ranajoy Punja, Cisco India and SAARC's vice-president of business development, advanced technologies, says that the Internet represents web surfing as well as many forms of video and entertainment. It has also become a way of being able to collaborate and share with colleagues and friends.

"The network will become the platform for many of life's and work's different experiences. We will see the network enabling a new way for people to experience each other. It's called peer-to-peer review."

So, go on. Throw that sheep at your colleague. ■

DINA MEHTA, media researcher, 2006

"Social networking sites may be faddish, but the phenomenon itself is long-term."